

The Vanishing Toast

A five-minute mini mystery for two curious people.

The situation

At 9:20 p.m., during a waterfront gala, the host raises a glass to thank the room. The handwritten toast is gone from the lectern. Four people were nearby. One detail in each statement exposes the person who took it.

Person	Their statement
Mara, event planner	"I was at the bar when the singer began. I heard the first note before I saw anyone leave the lectern."
Elliot, donor	"I stepped onto the terrace for fresh air. I came back when the clock struck 9:15."
June, photographer	"I was changing lenses beside the dance floor. I photographed the singer at 9:10, then the host at 9:20."
Theo, caterer	"I carried champagne to the terrace. I never went near the lectern."

The facts everyone agrees on

9:10	The singer begins the first song.
9:15	The host is still greeting guests by the terrace doors.
9:20	The host reaches the lectern and discovers the toast missing.
Important	The gala clock has been stopped at 9:12 all evening after a power flicker.

Your question: Who took the toast, and what gave them away? Discuss before turning the page.

Solution

The missing toast was taken by Elliot.

Why?

Elliot says he came back “when the clock struck 9:15.” But the gala clock has been frozen at 9:12 all evening. He could only know that the clock was wrong if he had been close enough to notice it - and he used a precise time to create a false alibi. The other statements can all be true.

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